RAMBAM'S INTRODUCTION TO HELEK: OLAM HABA & THE 13 PRINCIPLES

Moshe's Prophecy & the Torah: Principles 7 & 8

Rambam's Introduction to Helek, Part 13

Source: The Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek: Principle 7 (the uniqueness of Moshe's prophecy) and the opening of Principle 8 (*Torah min HaShamayim*)

Shiur: Part 13 of the series on the Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 13 January 2026 (on a patchy connection: "if I cut out, let me know")

These notes are based on the transcript of the recording.

Recap

The Thirteen Principles fall into three categories. **1–5: Hashem Himself. 6–9: revelation**, the relationship between Hashem and humans. Last week, **Principle 6**: **there is such a thing as prophecy**: Hashem **communicates with intellectually and morally developed human beings**.

"**The principle isn't that the words of the prophets are true.** It's that **Hashem relates to humans**."

Tonight: **Principle 7** quickly, then **Principle 8, *Torah min HaShamayim***, "a very important principle, with lots to discuss." **Seven is the longest principle; eight the second longest.**

Part 1: Principle 7: The Text

היסוד השביעי: נבואת משה רבנו עליו השלום. והוא שנאמין כי הוא אביהם של כל הנביאים אשר היו לפניו ואשר קמו אחריו, כולם הם תחתיו במעלה.

Moshe surpasses the prophets before him (Avraham, Yitzchak…) **and all who came after.**

"**This is interesting.** As a **principle of faith**, the Rambam asserts Moshe is greater than all who **will** come after. **So Mashiach, whoever and whenever he will be, won't be on Moshe's level. Not everyone agreed**, as we'll see."

והוא היה הנבחר מכל מין האדם, אשר השיג מידיעתו יתברך יותר מכל מה שהשיג או ישיג שום אדם שנמצא או שימצא.

He understood **God as much as possible**: more than anyone **has or ever will**.

Phrase	Meaning
הגיע התעלותו מן האנושיות עד המעלה המלאכותית, ונכלל במעלת המלאכים	He rose **to an angelic level**, **within the category of angels**
לא נשאר מסך שלא קרעו	**No barrier** he didn't break through
ולא מנעו מונע גופני	**Nothing physical** held him back from connecting to Hashem
ולא נתערב לו שום חסרון בין רב למעט	**No deficiency**, large or small
ונתבטלו ממנו הכוחות הדמיוניות והחושיות	His **physical senses nullified**: hence **40 days and nights without food or drink, three times**
ונבדל כח המתעורר והמשתוקק	His **appetitive drive removed**: he controlled it
ונשאר שכל בלבד	"**Pure intellect.** He had a human body, but he was essentially **an intellect walking within a human body**."
שהיה מדבר עם השם יתברך בלא אמצעיות מן המלאכים	He spoke with Hashem **directly, with no angelic intermediary**

(The Rambam's note that this needs long explanation, "I'll do it elsewhere," we read last week; he did it in Moreh, Section Two.)

Question: Is that prophecy, or just closeness?

"Other prophets foretold the future; Moshe didn't really. He was close to Hashem. Is that nevuah*?"*

"**Remember the key thing from last week.** The essence of prophecy is **not (A) telling other people information**, nor **(B) knowing the future**. Often it includes those. **The essence is a connection with Hashem through which you understand things about godliness**, the philosophy and theology of Hashem, **more than you ever did before**."

Part 2: The Four Differences

ואחזור לכונת זה היסוד השביעי, ואומר שנבואת משה רבנו עליו השלום נבדלת מנבואת כל הנביאים בארבעה דברים.

"Spoke": a borrowed term

"**When we say Hashem *spoke*:** remember Principle 3. **Hashem has no mouth**; there are **no sound waves**, since **nothing physical** about Him emits them. **'God spoke to Moshe' means a vision, a recognition, an understanding of God.**"

The source: Bamidbar 12

ויאמר שמעו נא דברי: אם יהיה נביאכם ה׳ במראה אליו אתודע, בחלום אדבר בו. לא כן עבדי משה, בכל ביתי נאמן הוא. פה אל פה אדבר בו, ומראה ולא בחידת, ותמנת ה׳ יביט. ומדוע לא יראתם לדבר בעבדי במשה?

Hashem to **Aharon and Miriam**: other prophets, **in a vision or a dream**. **Not so My servant Moshe**: **mouth to mouth**, **openly, not in riddles**; he **beholds the image of Hashem**. **Why weren't you afraid to**

speak against him?

#	Other prophets	Moshe	Rambam's proof
1. Intermediary	Through **an intermediary**, so the prophecy comes ***bechidot***, **as a riddle**, and must be **worked on**	**Directly**, **no riddles**	**פה אל פה אדבר בו**
2. Awake or asleep	**Only asleep**: **בחלום הלילה, בחזיון לילה**; by day only **אחר שתפול תרדמה על האדם**, **when all sensation is gone** and only the mind works (**מחזה ומראה: במראות אלהים**)	**By day, awake**, **standing between the two *keruvim***: **ונועדתי לך שם**	**ומראה ולא בחידות, ונועדתי לך שם**
3. Fear	**Lose their strength**, **fear and trepidation**, lose all sense of where they are	**As a friend speaks to a friend**	**פה אל פה**
4. Initiative	**Wait** until Hashem wishes to give prophecy	**Whenever Moshe wants** (once he's **prepared himself**) Hashem speaks to him	

On the intermediary:

"**The more intermediaries** between your vision and God, **the greater the effort** to understand the message. The Kabbalah and the Ramchal speak of the ***aspaklaria***, **a lens**: the prophets see through **dull, unpolished lenses** and **must decipher**. **Moshe: nothing in between.**"

("This is why Miriam and Aharon spoke against Moshe… let's not go into that now.")

Questions

Tehillim 99:6: משה ואהרן בכהניו ושמואל בקראי שמו, קראים אל ה׳ והוא יענם. *Some commentators say Shmuel is being compared to Moshe and Aharon.*

"The Gemara learns **שמואל בדורו כמשה בדורו**. **It's making a point:** don't think you only listen to Moshe and Aharon and **Shmuel, a later and lower generation**, less. **Give him the same *kavod***, listen to him equally. **It doesn't mean Shmuel is greater than Moshe. Of course not.**"

Bilaam: *In Balak, did Bilaam lose his strength and fall?*

"**Where did you get that he didn't?** He stands on the hills and has his prophecies. **He must have fallen** to the floor."

Part 3: Why So Much Emphasis?

The Rambam is **elaborate on both 7 and 8**: **Moshe's prophecy is unique**, and **the Torah today is exactly as in Moshe's day**.

"**I imagine there's an element of rebutting the Muslims and the Christians**, who claimed **the Torah changed**. **No prophet can arise like Moshe**, so it's not logical to **substitute the Torah of Moshe with the New Testament or the Quran**. **So-called prophets who called themselves prophets** can't replace it."

The verse, and how the Rambam reads it

ולא קם נביא עוד בישראל כמשה אשר ידעו ה׳ פנים אל פנים (Devarim 34:10)

Word	The Rambam's reading
קם	**The past**: none arose
עוד	**The future**: none will

"**That's not definitely the meaning of the verse**, but it's certainly how the Rambam reads it."

	Before Moshe	After Moshe
The Rambam	None like him	**None ever, including Mashiach**
Rav Yosef Albo	None like him	**Mashiach may be greater**

The Arizal and Chabad, again

The Arizal: Moshe was the greatest **prophet**, but in **Kabbalistic matters *Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai* was greater**. **The first Lubavitcher Rebbe** (the Ba'al HaTanya) develops this.

"**The Rambam would clearly say that's complete heresy. I don't really understand what it means**: surely **part of *nevuah* is understanding whatever Kabbalah teaches**, since it's teaching about God. **I'm just telling you what's written.**"

Part 4: Principle 7 in the Ani Ma'amin and Yigdal

	Text	Assessment
Ani Ma'amin	**שנבואת משה רבנו עליו השלום היתה אמיתית, ושהוא היה אב לנביאים, לקודמים לפניו ולבאים אחריו**	**"His prophecy was true" isn't the principle.** "Father of the prophets" **is the main point**. But it **misses the qualitative difference**
Yigdal	**לא קם בישראל כמשה עוד, נביא ומביט את תמונתו**	**Emphasises one of the four differences**: **a direct vision**, no intermediary

"They're not always precise."

Part 5: Principle 8: *Torah min HaShamayim*

"**I wouldn't say controversial, but there's a lot to dissect.** As we read, **count how many points** he makes."

היסוד השמיני: היות התורה מן השמים. והוא שנאמין כי כל התורה הזאת הנתונה על ידי משה רבנו עליו השלום, היא כולה מפי הגבורה. כלומר שהגיעה אליו כולה מאת ה׳, בענין שנקרא על דרך השאלה ״דבור״, ואין ידוע איך הגיעה אליו אלא הוא, משה עליו השלום, שהגיעה לו.

- **The whole Torah given through Moshe is entirely from Hashem.**

- **"Speech"** is a **borrowed term**. **No one knows *how* it reached him** except **Moshe himself**.

וכי הוא היה כסופר שקורין לפניו והוא כותב כולה, מאורעותיה וסיפוריה ומצוותיה. ולפיכך נקרא מחוקק.

Moshe was **like a scribe being dictated to**: events, stories, commandments. Hence he's called **מחוקק**, "**like a copyist**."

No verse is "less" Torah

ואין הפרש בין ״ובני חם כוש ומצרים ופוט וכנען״, ״ושם אשתו מהיטבאל בת מטרד בת מי זהב״, ״ותמנע היתה פילגש״, ובין ״אנכי ה׳ אלהיך״ ו״שמע ישראל״. כי הכל מפי הגבורה, והכל תורת ה׳ תמימה טהורה קדושה אמת.

"Seemingly superfluous" verses	The heart of the Torah
The sons of Cham	***Anochi Hashem Elokecha***
Mehetavel bat Matred bat Mei Zahav, wife of one of **the kings of Edom** (Vayishlach)	***Shema Yisrael***
Timna, concubine of Eliphaz son of Esav	

"No difference: every word is from the Almighty." *(The Rabbi: "God forbid I say they* are *superfluous; they seem so.")*

Standing for the Ten Commandments

The Rambam's famous *teshuvah: he opposed standing for the Aseret HaDibrot*: it implies **one part of the Torah is more important**, "**and that's not true**."

"**Ashkenazim do, and the Spanish and Portuguese communities do.** When we stand in our community, **I say every time**: we're not standing because it's more important, but because **within it are principles from which we learn the rest of the Torah**: a way to **remember the whole Torah**. **Anyone who says it's more important is going against this principle.**"

The worst heretic

וזה שאומר שכמו אלה הפסוקים והסיפורים משה ספרם מדעתו, הנה הוא אצל חכמינו ונביאינו כופר ומגלה פנים יותר מכל הכופרים, לפי שחשב שיש בתורה לב וקליפה, ושאלה דברי הימים והסיפורים אין תועלת בהם ושהם מאת משה רבנו עליו השלום.

Whoever says **Moshe wrote such verses on his own** is, for our Sages and prophets, **a heretic, more brazen than all heretics**: he treats the Torah as having **a core and a shell**, with **useless stories Moshe added**.

וזה ענין ״אין תורה מן השמים״, אמרו: הוא האומר שכל התורה מפי הגבורה חוץ מפסוק זה, שלא אמרו הקב״ה אלא משה מפי עצמו אמרו. וזהו ״כי דבר ה׳ בזה״.

Denying *Torah min HaShamayim* isn't only saying the Torah wasn't given; it's saying **"all of it, except this one verse Moshe added."** That is **"he has disgraced the word of Hashem."**

(On the text: "ה׳ יתברך וינזר ממאמר הכופרים" — this is a different text; it should read something else. He means: may Hashem be exalted above the words of the heretics.")

אלא כל דבור ודבור מן התורה יש בהם חכמות ופלאים למי שהבינם, ולא הושג תכלית חכמתה, ״ארוכה מארץ מדה ורחבה מני ים״. ואין לאיש אלא להלוך בעקבות דוד משיח אלהי יעקב...

Every word holds wisdom and wonders for one who understands; its depth is **"longer than the earth, wider than the sea."** Follow **King David** (in Tehillim) in valuing every verse.

The Oral Torah

וכן פירושה המקובל גם כן מפי הגבורה. וזה שאנו עושים היום תבנית הסוכה והלולב והשופר והציצית והתפילין וזולתם, הוא בעצמו התבנית שאמר השם למשה ואמר לנו, והוא מוסר השליחות נאמן בשליחותו.

The received explanation is also from Hashem. The form of **sukkah, lulav, shofar, tzitzit, tefillin** we make today is **the very form Hashem told Moshe** at Sinai **3,330+ years ago**.

והמאמר המורה על היסוד הזה הוא מה שנאמר: ויאמר משה בזאת תדעון כי ה׳ שלחני לעשות את כל המעשים האלה כי לא מלבי.

Moshe to **Korach's followers**: **"not from my own heart."** "**I'm just a copyist, passing the message on.**"

Part 6: The Four Points of Principle 8

A note on the text: "The real text says כי כל התורה הזאת המצויה בידינו: all the Torah in our hands. This text is a bit corrupted; in future I'll use a different one."

#	Point	In the Rabbi's words
1	**The Torah we have is Moshe's Torah**	"The Torah we read **Monday, Thursday and Shabbat** is the one given to Moshe **3,000 years ago**"
2	**Wholly divine**	"**Not even one word** can be attributed to Moshe's own authorship"
3	**All parts equally holy**	"**No distinction** between parts of the Torah"
4	**The Oral Torah is from Sinai**	"**How to make tefillin, how to make a sukkah**": passed down **generation to generation**

In the Ani Ma'amin and Yigdal

	Text	Covers
Ani Ma'amin	**שכל התורה המצויה עתה בידינו היא הנתונה למשה רבנו עליו השלום**	**Point 1 only** (the correct Rambam text); misses **2, 3** and **4**, "unless *kol haTorah* includes the Oral Torah"
Yigdal	**תורת אמת נתן לעמו אל, על יד נביאו נאמן ביתו**	**Point 2** (divine origin, through faithful Moshe)

"**They're abbreviations; they're not the main thing.**"

Robert's question

"I'm not saying I believe this, but: could one hold the Rambam's Torah was unchanged since Moshe, but scribal errors have crept in since? I believe there's one letter difference with the Teimani Sefer Torah."

"**Logically: when would more mistakes creep in, before the Rambam or after?**" **Before.** "**True.** So it's unlikely. **But keep the question in mind**; you'll see why."

Part 7: Point 1: "The Same Torah"

In academic terms: the **Masoretic text** is **the true text**, as against the **Samaritan text** and **the Dead Sea Scrolls**, "**and there are clear differences**."

"**I used to have a congregant**, I won't say which shul, who would **follow my Torah reading from his Samaritan copy**, and after Shabbat **point out the differences**."

	Masoretic	Samaritan
Bereishit 2:2	**ויכל אלהים ביום השביעי**	**ביום הששי**

Rashi asks: surely He **finished on the sixth day**? **The Midrash:** on the seventh **Hashem created rest**: "a deep idea." **The Samaritan text just says *the sixth*.** "**Important differences.**"

Only the words

Not what this principle requires:

- ***Te'amim***, the cantillation: "**a *machloket*** among our Sages when they came about; **some say as late as the 8th or 9th century**";

- ***Parashah petuchah* / *setumah***, *the open and closed sections;*

- **Tagin**, *the crowns on the letters;*

- *The script (*ketav*): "they may have had a different script.**"*

"**We're concerned with the exact words.**"

But even that is difficult

1. *Chaser* and *maleh* (Kiddushin 30a)

The Gemara counts **the middle letter / word / verse** of the Torah. A rabbi asks which half a letter belongs to. *"Bring a Sefer Torah and count!"* **אינהו בקיאי בחסירות ויתירות, אנן לא בקיאינן**: **they (earlier generations) were expert in defective and full spellings; we are not.** *(Said in the 300s–400s.)*

Word	*Chaser* (defective)	*Maleh* (full)
Yaakov	**יעקב**	e.g. **the end of Bechukotai** ,**יעקוב**
Asher hotzeiticha (*Aseret HaDibrot*)	without **yud**	with **yud**

Halachah: a Sefer Torah with ***chaser* written as *maleh*** *(or vice versa) is not* pasul***. "*I'm not talking about extra words or letters. Let me be very clear.**"

Pitchei Teshuvah cites a *posek* who argued that since **we aren't certain** what's *chaser* and *maleh*, **perhaps one shouldn't make a *berachah* on the Torah reading**. "**An extreme view; we don't hold that.** But it shows that **already in the Gemara there were differences**."

2. Tannaim with different texts

Verse	Our Torah	Rabbi Meir's Torah
וירא אלהים את כל אשר עשה והנה טוב מאד	(very) **מאד**	**מות** (**death**): **טוב מות**
ויעש... להם כתנות עור	with **ayin** (leather) **עור**	with **aleph** (**light**) **אור**

"**Of course we didn't take those on.** And it's **incredible**: Torahs across the world, **Sephardim, Ashkenazim, Teimanim**, are **almost identical**, a very few minor differences, **nothing substantially different in meaning**."

3. *Keri and ketiv*

Written one way, **read another**. Usually minor, but some major: in **Ki Tavo's curses**, **ישגלנה** written, **ישכבנה** read.

The Radak: variant texts arose during the first exile; when the **Anshei Knesset HaGedolah restored the Torah** they found small differences and **kept both**, one **written**, one **read**.

The Rabbi's conclusion: "**To say every single letter today is entirely the same as Moshe received: I think that's difficult**, and **I don't know that the Rambam meant it**. We see *chaser* and *maleh*, *keri* and *ketiv*, Tannaim with different texts. **Of course we believe in *Torah min HaShamayim***, the whole idea. But **the *vav* in Yaakov? I can't imagine that's part of this principle.**"

Part 8: Point 2 Begins: Did Moshe Write All of It?

Bava Batra 15a: the last eight verses, which describe **Moshe's death**. *How could Moshe write them?*

View	
One opinion	**Yehoshua wrote them**, not Moshe
The other	**Moshe wrote them, *with tears***

(To be continued next week.)

Summary

1. **Principle 7:** Moshe is **father of all prophets before and after**: **angelic**, no barrier, **pure intellect**, **no intermediary**. For the Rambam, **not even Mashiach** will equal him (**Albo** disagrees).
2. **Prophecy's essence is connection to Hashem**, not foretelling the future.
3. **Four differences** (Bamidbar 12): **no intermediary** (no riddles, no *aspaklaria*); **awake, by day**; **no fear**, as friend to friend; **at will**.
4. **Why the emphasis:** a rebuttal of **Christian and Muslim** claims that the Torah was **superseded or changed**. **קם = past, עוד = future** is **the Rambam's reading**.
5. **The Arizal/Tanya** claim about Rashbi: "**the Rambam would call it heresy**."
6. **Principle 8, four points: our Torah is Moshe's**; **wholly divine**; **all equally holy** (hence the Rambam **against standing** for the Ten Commandments); **the Oral Torah from Sinai**.

7. **"The same Torah" means the words**, not *te'amim*, *tagin*, sections or script. Even so, ***chaser/maleh***, **Rabbi Meir's Torah** and ***keri/ketiv*** make **letter-perfect identity** "difficult," and probably **not the Rambam's intent**.
8. **The last eight verses**: **Yehoshua**, or **Moshe in tears**.

Coming Up

Next week: continuing **Principle 8**: **was every word written by Moshe from Hashem?**, then **equal holiness** and **the Oral Torah**, and on to **Principle 9**. And "**keep Robert's question in mind**."

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